

the Christianised reformism of the Brahmo Samaj—while reversing its overt markers. And the caste-free Dayanand Anglo-Vedic schools and colleges were modelled explicitly on Christian institutions (a model the RSS too was to later adopt). Then, the Arya Samaj's *shuddhi* movement, focused on weaning back converts, took on such a co-optive ambition that it became a predatory threat for the canonically Punjabi religion: Sikhism. And it responded with its own self-defining movement—the Singh Sabha, which de-Brahminised the Khalsa, rebuffed the paternalistic claim that Sikhism was a part of the Hindu spectrum, clarified the outer boundaries of an autonomous religion, and birthed modern Sikhism as we know it today.

Its other profound effect was on caste. In 1873, Ditt Singh, "a lame, dark man" from the manual scavenging caste—who now carry the appellations Balmiki (among Hindus) and Mazhabi Sikh—inaugurated Punjab's first wave of mass conversions to Christianity by taking the baptismal sacrament in Sialkot. His caste fellows followed in such a self-generated surge that even the Church was left nonplussed at the subaltern harvest. It had been angling for elite converts, but its prize catches—like the teenaged Dalip Singh, Maharaja Ranjit Singh's son (who later reconverted), or 'Raja Sir' Harnam Singh of Kapurthala—became showpiece rarities as the real ferment was felt on the ground.

Dalits total 31.9 per cent in present-day Punjab, the highest ratio for any Indian state, and the former manual scavenging caste accounts for 13.5 per cent (Mazhabi Sikhs: 10 per cent, Balmikis: 3.5 per cent). As the most stigmatised among castes, the latter cluster formed the bulk of conversions over that first half-century. The reason is not hard to see: emancipation, pure and simple, a way to unshackle themselves from centuries of debasement and exploitation. "Punjab Christianity became de facto a movement for the uplift of Untouchables, perhaps the first one in modern history," wrote sociologist Mark Juergensmeyer in his 1982 book, *Religion as Social Vision*. The first converts settled down in new locales—especially in nearly totally Christian villages around Jalandhar cantonment, whose denizens sometimes made up "the entirety of Indian hockey teams", according to novelist Desraj Kali.

Undivided Punjab's Christian population went up from a few thousands in 1870 to half a million in 1930, before the wave abated. Partition deposited the bulk of them on the other side of the Radcliffe Line. A sedate presence of decades followed, with the old churches becoming elegant variations on city landscapes, and settling into the usual humanitarian work—schools, colleges, hospitals. In 2003, then minorities commission chief Tarlochan Singh even struck a standstill agreement between the Sikh establishment, Catholics and Protestants: conversion, anyway happening at a glacial pace, was to be abjured. The Christian community remained small, just 1.26 per cent in the 2011 census; Sikhs (57.7 per cent) and Hindus (38.5 per cent) together accounted for 96 per cent of Punjab's population.

Things began to change when Tamil evangelist Paul Dhinakaran arrived sometime in the 2000s, with his Charismatic toolkit forged in the hyper-dramatic American TV evangelist mould. In his wake, former acolyte Narula and others spread out the whole Pentecostal spiritual buffet—the trance-like glossolalia or 'speaking in tongues', prayer as a direct bodily communion with divinity attained via music and dance, ecstatic delirium, wondrous acts of faith healing. And Punjab, still half-submerged in multiple forms of trauma—the militancy years, farm distress, a drug-addled generation—proved fertile soil for what they call the "Christianity for the underclasses of the world".

A CRUCIBLE FOR RELIGIONS

On the ground, though, Punjab had continued to be a crucible for religions, sects and competitive evangelisms. Till the 1891 census, the 'untouchable' castes were not being enumerated as Hindu. And indeed, the manual scavengers had a religion of their own—the Bala Shahi cult, "neither Hindu nor Musalman, but with a priesthood and ritual peculiar to itself", as Richard Temple recorded in 1884—which the Arya Samajis later Hinduised by aligning Bala Shah with the Valmiki of Ramayana. Sikhism, starting off with a distinctly egalitarian ethos before paradoxically developing into a quasi-fiefdom of the powerful Jat community, absorbed them as Mazhabi Sikhs—but the estrangement lingered.

On the outer edges of Sikhism, the Nirankaris and Namdharis believe in living gurus—so do the Radhasoa-